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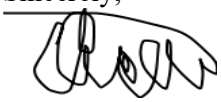
Dear DTA Committee Member,

On behalf of the English Department, I am very pleased to nominate Salem Martinez for the Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. When the Collegium of University Teaching Fellows (CUTF) faculty committee voted unanimously to accept Salem's proposal (the only unanimous "yes" out of more than 40 submissions), members cited the course's outstanding design. Salem's "Death and (Re)Birth: Afrofuturism" puts into play Gloria Ladson-Billings' (1995) three main results for Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (students achieve academically, demonstrate cultural competence, and understand and critique the existing social order). One of Salem's learning goals for the course is to have "Students ask what it means to create new worlds in a society that still subjects Black people to harm and violence." In fact, Salem's design, including materials, assignments, and goals, reflects Django Paris's 2012 update of Ladson-Billings, espousing a Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy that "seeks to perpetuate and foster--to sustain--linguistic, literate, and cultural pluralism as part of the democratic project of schooling." Since 2012, the need to sustain multiethnic and multilingual cultural products has become more important and more fraught. Thus, Salem's teaching intervenes in a cultural debate happening across the US.

Teachers are also debating student grades. While many instructors are anxious about grade inflation and seek to practice more "rigor" in assessing student work, Salem has adopted and adapted an "ungrading" system of student evaluation. Salem learned about ungrading from Professor Jennifer Doyle, who borrowed the idea from Jesse Stommel. Consistent with Salem's commitment to culturally sustaining teaching practices, he turned to ungrading in response to the failing grades that disproportionately went to students of color. In reading student course feedback, one gets the idea, though, that like Ladson-Billings's Culturally Responsive Pedagogy, Salem's use of ungrading is "just good teaching." Students feel liberated to risk more and learn more when they do not orient their writing to the achievement of points or grades. Students also report working harder to understand what constitutes good writing, rather than trying to fit their writing to the standards of an instructor. As Salem has continued to revise ungrading, he has thought to include more checkpoints for student accountability: flexibility meets the limits of the instructor. Still, the focus is always on student growth, growth promoted by feedback that follows evidence-based practices of being timely, precise, encouraging, suggestive, and interrogative. Salem's dedication and diligence in providing stimulating feedback leads, by all student accounts, to improved student writing and increased student initiative for improving their work.

Salem has earned this award though years of courageous, caring teaching. I strongly encourage you to recognize this superb teacher with a Distinguished Teaching Award.

Sincerely,



Christopher M. Mott
TA Coordinator

Self-Statement: (750 Words Max)

Over the course of my time at UCLA, I have taught across a wide range of courses within English, Latino/a, and African American Studies both at the upper and lower-division levels. I have garnered a wealth of experience from professors I have served as an assistant to as well as the classes where I have served as the primary instructor. As an assistant, I contributed to the courses English 100: Ways of Reading Race (Fall 2020) and English 91C: Intro to Fiction (Winter 2021), which both focused on literature coming largely from contemporary Latino/a fiction and non-fiction. When I have had the opportunity to be the primary instructor, I have used the English 4W and 4WX courses (Fall 2021, Winter 2022, Spring 2022, Fall 2024, Spring 2025) to sharpen the critical ability to translate one's own scholarly research into an enriching pedagogical experience for our undergraduate students.

This culminated in my selection into the Collegium of University Teaching Fellows (Spring 2024) where I taught a course I designed named "Death and (Re)Birth: Afrofuturism and the Building of New Worlds". Of more than 65 course proposals, mine was the only one to receive unanimous approval from the faculty selection committee. Moreover, my ardent commitment to developing my pedagogical skills is reflected in my completion of the Writing Programs' Graduate Certificate in Writing Pedagogy with a Writing in the Disciplines Emphasis. Cumulatively, my commitment to student-centered teaching that actively engages students and adheres to best practices of inclusion is reflected through my ungrading syllabus as well as a myriad of individual and collective writing assignments.

By following an ungraded course structure, the barrier of a grade is lifted from students' psyches, resulting in better engagement and mastery of material. While ungrading can be misunderstood by students as lacking structure, they learn that autonomy in learning and structure are not in conflict. I demonstrate this by scaffolding mandatory assignments. Their Statement of Intention, for example, lays the groundwork for their workload, and along with their concluding End-Of-Term Reflection, is where students express the most autonomy over what work they do and how they engage with the material. The Vocabulary Essay and Annotated Bibliography, however, build so that by the time students write their 2000-word essay, they produce writing that informs their thinking as well as ensures they have completed necessary steps in writing successfully, such as engaging in scholarly research and implementing sound citations.

Since my classes center on the study of culture--how culture is created, how systems of power affect individual and collective lives, and how we might have a hand in their creation--my pedagogy reflects this investment in both the content of my courses and how we interpret material. The reading I assign is theoretically dense, ranging from Black Studies to Queer and Affect Theory. I support their learning through a Keywords Assignment. In small groups, students identify 3-5 keywords that capture main ideas within the reading. Then, they define those keywords in their own words before sharing with the class. Since they complete work in a

shared Google Doc, the result is a massive archive of keywords and ideas they can in future assignments.

While I am a literary scholar, I also encourage students to see all cultural production as sites of learning and investigation. For this reason, I always go beyond literary objects, incorporating visual and sonic analysis as often as I can. While teaching a segment on Afrofuturism, Black Feminism, and Queerness, students close read Janelle Monae music videos. They are asked to identify elements of the music video, ranging from the lyrics to cinematography, to produce a close reading that connects to main ideas from the weeks' readings. In another exercise, students do a similar task with a cookbook called *Black Food: Stories, Art, & Recipes From Across the African Diaspora.* This exercise begins with students individually writing about their personal relationship to food and culture before identifying in small groups how the author of their assigned reading excerpt conceptualizes the relationship between food, power, and the shaping of world and culture around us.

Together, these approaches teach students that regardless of the medium, the world around us is constantly inviting us to listen, interpret, and synthesize our experiences. By remaining curious and critical, my classroom empowers students to take their skills beyond the classroom and into the world, instilling the dire importance of the Humanities, and serving as a bridge between their academic work and how they show up in their communities onward.

Teaching Philosophy: (1,000 Words Max)

My teaching commitments are best surmised by a singular but powerful word; transformation. Student transformation through learning begins by re-centering the student as co-creators in their own academic and intellectual pursuits; it is my job to guide and support their growth rather than position myself as an arbiter of knowledge.

The process of transforming power dynamics in the classroom is exemplified in my usage of an ungrading system. Students are given a list of mandatory assignments that equal 55 points earned in the course, along with additional assignments they choose to earn up to an additional 45 points, totaling 100 points. One mandatory assignment a 5-7 page essay that they revise 2 times. Rather than writing multiple stand-alone essays, students engage with the piece several times, allowing me to engage with their writing and thinking as it develops over time. It teaches students the often-overlooked writing skills of revision as they learn how to receive, evaluate, and apply feedback. This assignment helps me meet students where they are at; in some instances, this means alleviating the culture shock experienced by transfer students in their first quarters at UCLA. For others, it means mitigating the disadvantage they might feel as a non-Humanities major. It also helps me check in on students who have difficulty asking for help; if students are not adhering to the plan they set out for themselves, I initiate contact to see if they need an adjustment. The intention and care built into my curriculum benefits my student's significantly; it is not uncommon for students to share at the end of the quarter it is, "the first class they have been treated like a whole person".

I also help students transform their understanding of learning as a communal, rather than individual, pursuit. In my Critical Reading and Writing courses, students co-write together in groups or pairs. In one exercise, students got into small groups and drawing from that week's lesson on close reading, wrote a paragraph together that close read one stanza from Sonia Sanchez's poem "Elegy (for MOVE and Philadelphia)". When each group finished, they presented their work to the class, where we stitched together each groups' analysis and filled in the gaps missing from trying to perform critical analysis on only a fragment of a literary work. Students learned how to collaborate and write with their partners, but also came to appreciate each other as co-constitutive in their learning process. Symbolized through their incomplete close reading, they understood that their learning becomes fragmented without the knowledge everyone brings to the classroom. Sanchez's poem is also an indictment of the incomplete journalism that failed to accurately report on the infamous 1985 bombing of a city block in Philadelphia that, even today, remains largely unknown. Students reflected on the importance of collaborating with members within and outside of their own communities, the political implications of erasure, and how race and gender inform productions of knowledge.

I want my students to leave my class better equipped as readers, writers, and thinkers. I also want them value literary studies as a discipline. In a 4WX class I taught called "Liberation Through Decarceration," students read a wide range of texts addressing prison abolition and various forms of mutual aid necessary to support formerly incarcerated community members.

After learning that private corporations have vested financial interests in keeping prisons across the country open, one student aptly asked, “If private corporations currently profit off of prisons, and it’s true that many prisoners need better mental health services, but that mental health facilities can also act like prisons, what would keep private corporations from simply investing in mental health facilities and making the problem even harder to fix?” As this student struggle to articulate this question, I knew that I was witnessing, in real time, the transformation of her worldview. While the weight of discovery can feel paralyzing, this class had a community engagement aspect built into it. Each student completed 20 or more hours of community service with a chosen organization that they identified as beneficial to the work of decarceration. Some students worked with Initiate Justice, a non-profit that organizes around prison abolition. These students saw the material power their writing could have as they assisted Initiate Justice with a slide deck that refocused their mission statement. My students reflected at the end of the quarter how this experience helped them to not feel helpless when presented with serious topics like prison abolition and were glad to have had a way to transform the lessons they learned each week into action.

Recently, I have had to come to grips with the challenge that has arisen from a young generation of students navigating a rapidly expanding technological world, transforming my own teaching to adapt to student’s lessening ability to maintain the attention required to critically read and write. One way I have begun to address this is by incorporating short meditation exercises in class. Students take what might be their first deep breaths of the day and I guide them through a short meditation where we focus on our breath, how it feels to be in our bodies, and I prompt them to develop a dialogue with an assignment they are working on. They then start a writing exercise wherein they are instructed to write uninhibited. This has had a net positive effect for students. I am privileged to watch as students’ shoulders relax, their breathing deepens, and their minds attune to their relaxing nervous systems. This produces increased focus on their writing and more sustained learning because they engage for longer periods of time, both inside and outside of class time. As their relationship to their own minds transforms, so does their relationship to their work.

For myself, addressing this challenge allows me to embody my consistent pursuit of transformation, as I adapt my own pedagogical practices to meet the moment, shifting to support our students and champion their growth as young academics and developing adults.

Teaching Artifacts (1-5 Artifacts; 10 Pages Max)

Teaching Artifact #1: SET Feedback

- Before taking this class, I had very little interest in the subject, but over the course of the quarter, I am glad I took this class. While the assigned readings could feel overwhelming at times, the discussions we had in class helped me understand them better. I also haven't had a class where I needed to participate vocally as much as this class, so it definitely felt interesting. I also liked the smaller class size; I think it made participating so much easier. Salem is very understanding and I can feel that he truly cares about us not only as students but as individuals as well. I liked the peer feedback we got to do with our classmates on our 2000-word essay. I really liked how we had a different day for thesis revisions and body paragraph revisions. The pacing was perfect and I wish we had a little more time in class for it. This class has taught me valuable themes of intersectionality and the different types of injustice that exist that I previously was not aware of.

- I think that the structure of the course was really good because it was ungraded. It takes the pressure off so that we can concentrate on learning and doing things in the best way possible. Salem is very understanding, I feel like he really cares about his students and pays attention to what we are doing or not. When he changed the required assignments, I wasn't worried at all because I knew he would do it in a way that only benefitted the students. The readings were all very interesting, I really liked the short stories that he shared, as well as the academic texts. He was also really good at making us engage with the readings more deeply. His lectures were very helpful to me as a writer, I think that it made me approach writing with less anxiety by doing it through the strategies he shared. I think Salem is an amazing teacher, not only because of his ability to make us understand the material better, but also because he actually cares about students.

- 1. My favorite part of the discussions was going through the worksheets, since they helped me to make my ideas and understanding concrete. It was especially effective to go over the worksheets step-by-step with my peers because then we could build upon a diverse range of ideas.

  I did not dislike any part of the discussion, since most activities done in the section were productive and engaging.

  2. The worksheets were extremely helpful. The readings were approachable yet complex, so a supporting structure like a worksheet made sure that I was able to extract the main themes from the texts.

- The great strength Salem has as an instructor is letting the class take over the discussion rather than having the class/discussion be solely lecture base. Salem doesn't believe that we will truly absorb the information when it's only them who present and discuss in front of class. Salem created an environment that was welcoming and open to any ideas, very opposed to curriculums that only believe certain views are considered relevant or intellectual. When starting class Salem allowed their first few minutes to be open for discussion of any real world issues that were occurring. When it came to the sad tragedy of the Robb Elementary School Shooting we discussed our concerns and personal beliefs on how we could prevent this from occurring again. These opportunities to speak and share our opinions furthered my understanding of the material we were discussing as I felt truly involved and could express my thoughts freely.

- Instructor Martinez shares presentations that apply to the theme of the class while keeping the class engaged. We have lots of group activities which means we learn from our peers as much as we do from him. The readings he provides are thought-provoking such as: The Uses of Anger: Women Responding to Racism by Audre Lorde (Book: Sister Outsider) and The Case for Rage (Introduction) by Cherry. These interesting reads spark conversations in our classroom and is a space where our concerns about the world and critiques about the readings/film can be shared. A required reading in this class is the book, The Fifth Season, which was not only interesting but connected to Black affect, the focus of the class. One thing I will take away from this class is the interest in reading because as someone who does not read books often, I was able to read The Fifth Season in less than a week.

- Salem was a really engaging teacher that made me think about perspectives -- regarding the world, affect theory, racism, and just our social construct as a whole -- in ways that I had never thought of before. Salem always encouraged us (students) to share our opinions and thoughts on every theme/ topic to promote discussion among peers in ways that expanded our minds and diversified our ideas. He also made sure to choose eye-opening texts for us to read, such as "The Uses of Anger: Women Responding to Racism" by Lorde and "What Feels More Than Feeling? Theorizing the Unthinkability of Black Affect" by Palmer, which really struck out to me and made me grow as not only just a citizen of humanitarian society, but also as a scholar in thinking about current social justice issues. I also felt like Salem was very considering and understanding of student's situations, taking time to address current events and how we were affected, rather than just pretending like they don't exist. As a STEM major, I really enjoyed this class, because it allowed me to explore texts, theories, and political ideas that were novel and fascinating to me. I believe that Salem will make a great professor one day, after he obtains his PhD, in a way where he will have a real impact on students and make students think twice about how they originally thought of our social world -- even after the class ends.

- I think my TA was very knowledgeable on the course material, always had organized and worthwhile section presentations that I found to be valuable, and was very understanding of the difficulties of remote learning. I also think my TA was approachable and helpful during office hours and always provided detailed and helpful feedback on writing assignments. I also liked that my TA integrated group work during sections to discuss with other people from the class.

- Salem is hands down one of the best instructors I've had at UCLA. They work hard to make the classroom a welcoming space where we all feel like equals. Their love for the subject is clear and honestly makes it easy for the students to enjoy the content as well. They prioritized the class' well-being and adjusted the course when necessary. They handled this quarter admirably and I am so grateful. I am walking away with a strong interest in Afrofuturism, and I will probably keep taking classes on it if I can. Salem really was incredible and they're going to make the most wonderful professor (if that's what they plan to do). Thanks for a great final quarter at UCLA :)

- This Discussion really benefitted my understanding to the course. Online learning is difficult, especially when lecture is not recorded and does not have a real structure to it. I valued this discussion section and saw it as a backbone to my learning; therefore I have nothing but good things to say about my TA Stephanie. Perhaps my only issue would be that presentations were not as guided, and perhaps utilizing slides and presentations while explaining a topic would be more beneficial than a google doc. I did enjoy collaboration on the doc worksheets though, just presentations and class explanations I feel would benefit from a proper presentation.

- Overall Salem was one of the most engaging, knowledgeable, understanding, and caring teachers that I have had! He always put the interests of his students first and clearly loves what he does. He encouraged us to share and have class discussions while making everyone feel comfortable in doing so. I found this to be one of my favorite parts of his class because it helped me learn so much to hear from other people's perspectives alongside Salem's conversation guidance. By having a no grade system it is clear that his objective was to actually help his students become better writers and he wasn't expecting everyone to spit out work that just checked certain boxes and call it a day. There was always extensive feedback on our work that helped me grow and showed how much he cared about our writing.
  I honestly don't really have any critiques. I loved the way the course was structured, the way each class period was structured, the way he is as a person and teacher, and overall the environment he created in the classroom.

Teaching Artifact #2: Excerpt of Ungrading Syllabus/Scaffolded Assignments

Course Structure

This is an "ungraded" syllabus. You get full credit for each assignment you complete. I use a points-based grading system. Your final grade is based on the points you earn by completing specific assignments.

There are a few assignments required of all students. Those assignments add up to 45 points. Beyond those requirements, you choose what assignments and tasks you would like to do.

Although no assignment will be given a grade, I will give feedback. I will ask questions and make comments that engage your work, rather than simply evaluate it. Some students may find this structure confusing and even stressful at first. I ask for your trust: once we get going, this will be way less stressful than a traditional/graded class.

Revise & Resubmit

All work needs to meet a minimum standard. If your assignment needs more work, I will ask you to *revise and resubmit* your work — I will make clear what needs fixing. Once you have made your improvements and submitted the work, you will get full credit. Examples of the kinds of mistakes that lead me to ask for students to revise and submit their work include:

- Submission is below minimum word count requirement.
- Problems with citational practice.
- Absence of direct engagement with the text.
- Major and yet fixable writing glitches — where the writing is getting in the way of realizing your work's potential.
- Summary essays have the shape of notes taken while reading.
- Submitted work does not address some aspect of assignment directions

In general, work in this zone would normally receive a B- or lower. If those grades are normal for you in other classes — don't worry! This is the class where you get to NOT be a B- or C student (or a B+ or A student). In this class, you might have to work a little harder in some ways, but you get to do that work in a grade-free zone. In my experience, the students I ask to revise & submit only have this happen once and learn a ton by addressing those issues.

Choosing your assignments

Most of your points are awarded based on assignments/tasks that you choose.

- You will propose a plan and explain your intentions regarding your work in this class — this is your first assignment; this is the assignment that many students often need to revise and resubmit.
- As the course progresses, you may need to change your plan. This is OK.
- It is possible to get a very high final grade by concentrating on contributing to class sessions.
- It is possible to aim for a final grade in the B-zone, and make this class easier for you.

Deadlines

The most challenging part of this kind of class can be keeping on top of deadlines. The ungraded syllabus only works, however, if I can pace assignments so that I have time to give you feedback. Procrastination can be tempting when assignment choice is left to you.

- Deadlines span weekends – anything turned in from midnight on Friday through before midnight on Monday is on time.
- If you have *something*, turn it in. If you are having serious problems with the deadline, please get in touch.
- I will be checking in on students who are not putting points on the board. But my ability to support you will be enhanced if every student who is having trouble, either by missing deadlines for assignments or falling behind in their goals, takes the step of letting me know so we can work on it together. Communicate with me.

Assignments & Point Values

Required Assignments (highlighted): 55 points total

Statement of Intention & Plan (5 points)
Vocabulary/Keyword Essay (10 points)
Annotated Bibliography (10 points)
2,000 Word Essay (15 points)
2,000 Word Essay Revision (10 points)
Self-assessment/Reflection (5 points)

Optional Assignments: 45 point maximum

You decide what other assignments you would like to do from choices below. You do not HAVE to do 45 points worth of work, 45 points is the amount needed to earn an A+.

Final grade for class:

Required assignments (55) + optional assignments (up to 45) = 100

Final letter grade to point scale:

A+:	95-100
A:	90-94
B+:	85-89
B:	80-84
C+:	75-79
C:	70-74
D:	60-69
F:	0-59

2 points	**5 points**	**10 points**	**15 points**
Attend a class session. You can receive a max 26 points (13 sessions required to get full attendance points).	Assist with leading discussion during a class Repeatable for max 10 points (can do up to 2 sessions).	Required (1): Vocabulary/ keyword essay (~750-1000 words) Repeatable for max of	Required: (1) 2000-word essay on one of the week's themes in the course. Should draw from previously submitted work.

		30 points (up to 3 essays).	
	Required: Statement of Intention & Plan	Required: Annotated bibliography (at least 8 sources)	
	Required: End-of-term Reflection/Self-Assessment	Required (1): Revision of 2,000 word essay. Can be repeated a 2nd time for max 20 points.	
		Summary essay (~1250-1500-words) May address any work in the course folder.	
		Creative Option(s): Performative writing assignment (~1250-1500 words)	

Statement of Intention & Plan (~750 words)

After looking through the syllabus during the first week of class, tell me what assignments you plan to do. This is a statement of intention, not a contract: it is ok if your plans change as the quarter progresses! Your plan should include the following:

- List assignments you plan to tackle with total number of points
- Explain what texts you will address, even if this is pure speculation — show me you have looked at the list of readings and thought about how they connect with your interests.
- Tell me what you are looking forward to
- Tell me what looks challenging
- Describe your strengths as a student
- Describe areas of your work you want to improve

Vocabulary/Keyword Essay (~750-1000 words)

Choose one of the terms below and write a reflection on how this term is useful, important, necessary to the project of thinking about race, worldmaking, and futurity across one or several types of genres. Your reflection should show awareness of the term's dictionary definition and (more importantly) explore what, about your object, that term helps you to name. Make use of other readings (optional), offer not only a definition, but a description of how it appears in your object of focus and how it works. In most instances, however, the word itself will make no appearance in the object you choose to write about — but it is nevertheless necessary to a conversation about the object's meaning/relevance. You can also add and propose terms for this assignment too, just be sure to run them by me for approval.

You are welcome to do three throughout the quarter. You can expand this into your 2000-word essay.

Aesthetics Affect Afrofuturism Afropessimism Archive Blackness	Body Celebration Collaboration Complicity Difference Dystopia	Family Flesh Fugitivity Futurity Gender Human	Identification Materiality Motherhood Impression Object Oppression	Otherness Queer Resistance Speculation Survival Surface	Technology Touch Utopia Visceral Worldmaking Whiteness

Annotated Bibliography

Look through the themes for each week of the course, as well as the keywords/terms provided for the vocabulary/keyword essays. Choose one and gather at least 8 sources that further your understanding of that theme. ALL of those sources need to be scholarly: begin by doing keyword searches on scholar.google.com. Look at UCLA's online database for peer-reviewed articles and academic books.

For each entry, you need to let me know what the source is. For example, "Blackness and Nothingness (Mysticism in the Flesh)" is an essay written by the scholar, Fred Moten, and was published in 2013 in the academic journal, *South Atlantic Quarterly*. Next, you will provide 2-3 sentence summary of the article along with another 2-3 sentences explaining the significance of the source. Why did you choose it? How does it further your understanding of the theme that you chose?

Spend time with the work that is most on-point, and/or that really helps you to understand the stakes of your project. Write a couple paragraphs for the most inspiring/relevant texts on your bibliography (you can annotate 4-5 texts). You are welcome to list more works on the bibliography but are only required to annotate the ones you are likely to use in writing your paper.

2000-Word Essay

Expand on previous work in a summary and/or vocabulary/keyword essay or start from scratch: a 2000-word essay exploring texts and ideas mobilized by your reading, viewing, and writing thus far in the course. The essay needs to move between close reading of readings in and explorations of Afrofuturism as a field that shifts, affects, and transforms how we think of racial difference in the pursuit of creating better worlds. Your essay should focus on one cultural object of your choosing – whether that be a novel, a performance documented on YouTube, an artwork, a television show, film, music album, etc.

While your annotated bibliography just needed citational information, the final paper will require the consistent and correct usage of a citation style of your choosing (MLA, Chicago, etc.). You can find examples of correct citations online, although I will be providing resources for MLA citations for you.

You have 2 options:

Option 1: Build from your annotated bibliography. Your essay should be about that bibliography.

Option 2: Use your summary and/or vocabulary/keyword essay(s) as a foundation for developing a new final essay that expands upon the questions and interests that have been guiding and moving you through the course.

End-of-Term Reflection/Self-Assessment (~750 words)

Write a narrative of your experience and trajectory in the course. This is an opportunity to step back and reflect on the work you've done. Address the following: What did you enter into the class knowing or not knowing? How does the work you've done throughout the term speak to or diverge from your initial statement of intention and plan? What ideas, concepts, and themes became the most significant to you? What surprised you? Where did you hit walls or find difficulty? Where did you improve? What questions are you walking away with? Refer to your own assignments that you chose to do for the term to speak to your experience of the course. This is due before the end of exam week.

Teaching Artifact #3: Keywords Assignment (In-Class Group Activity)

Keywords Activity:

Afrofuturism: The World of Black Sci-Fi and Fantasy Culture by Ytasha Womack

Instructions: In each of your groups, discuss this week's reading as well as some of the ideas that you wrote in your freewrite. Amongst yourselves, identify 3-5 keywords that you believe get to the core ideas Womack is conveying in *Afrofuturism*. In essence, these keywords should highlight the main ideas within Womack's introduction, or things that you otherwise deem as necessary to understanding the core of her writing.

Group 1	Names: Isabel Pelayo, Sarah Ransing, Carla Wilfert, Ken Cheng, Kayla Law
Keyword	Definition
Evolution	In Afrofuturism, Womack began explaining the neglection of people of color in media, with many examples to support this primary point that became the backbone throughout the passage. By the end of the reading, however, we were able to observe progress and read about the many breakthrough's that the black community has accomplished within numerous pieces of popular media.
Empowerment	How seeing people that look like you represented in popular media can be empowering and inspire individuals to seek out or even create their own media that represents people like them / people from their communities.

Representation	Representation in media is important. People of all cultures and all communities should be able to see themselves represented in media.
Cosplay	People of color being misrepresented by Western actors/actresses up until new Sci-Fi movies like The Matrix and Black Panther were made
Afrofuturism	Afrofuturism is a term that describes more than just a movement but rather an entire culture connected by unspoken bonds over Sci-Fi and pop culture that are shaped by African American history.

Teaching Artifact #4: Visual Media Analysis Assignment (In-Class Group Activity)

Instructions: Just like we did with the film *Black Panther*, take a few minutes within your group to decide on a specific scene you would like to analyze. Then, pick an element from the film worksheet that you would like to analyze the scene with. What is important here is that you use these elements to describe *how* a specific theme or meaning is formulated through the specific element that you choose.

Group 1 Names: Cristi Myers, Kayla Law, Araceli Valladare, jon q

1. What scene are you focusing on? (0:40-0:52) Janelle Monae is sitting on a throne-like chair with dancers around her. "A-town, made it out there /Straight out of Kansas City, yeah we made it out there / Celebrated, graduated, made it pass, fail / Sassy, classy, Kool-Aid with the kale / Momma was a G, she was cleanin' hotels / Poppa was a driver, I was workin' retail"
2. Which element are you focusing on? story/plot/narrative, shot (tilting)
3. What theme or meaning is formed through this scene and how does this element convey meaning to the viewer? The lyrics during this scene seem to be a response to people who doubt the excellence of black women and the extent they can succeed. During this scene, the lyrics are "Straight out of Kansas City, yeah we made it out there/Celebrated, graduated, made it pass, fail." By talking about the accomplishments she and other women may have had, she is empowering the black community as a whole. The lyrics "Sassy, classy" reference how Janelle is fully claiming her identity. Black women are often stereotyped as being sassy, but Janelle reclaims this narrative and turns it into something positive. She

also aligns being sassy with being classy which further dispels racist stereotypes about the sophistication of black people. Janelle is reclaiming these words and assigning them to her own identity as a way to empower black women.

The camera/shot tilts in the same direction as Janelle and the dancers. The camera tilt conveys a sense of power and control. Since the shot is tilting in the same direction as Janelle, it reinforces the idea that she has the control over her own narrative.

Teaching Artifact #5: *Black Food: Stories, Art, & Recipes From Across the African Diaspora* individual and group assignment

Instructions: Today we're going to be looking at excerpts from Bryant Terry's book *Black Food: Stories, Art, & Recipes From Across the African Diaspora*. This book is all at once a recipe book, collection of essays, poetry, art, and music. It is a beautiful collection that thinks about Black foodways within America and around the world, and today we will be thinking about some of these intersections and how they relate to bigger questions of how food and food security is a key component of the liberation of marginalized communities through decarceration work.

Individual Writing: To start, we are going to begin with a freewrite. Take a few minutes to respond to the following questions:

What kind of role does food play within your life? Do you have certain family or cultural traditions that are meaningful to you? Spiritual or religious ceremonies or traditions you follow? What are they? Are there any dishes that have a particular sentimental value to you? What are they and why?

Group Writing: Now, in groups, you will each be given a short excerpt from Terry's book. Together you will read this, listen to your assigned song, and answer the following questions.

1. Summarize the essay for the class in no more than 5 sentences
2. What particular role or power does the author see food playing in their lives and the world around them? In other words, what does the author argue food has the ability to do other than provide us with the energy we need to live and breathe?
3. After listening to the song assigned to you, briefly theorize/perform a close reading in which you make a connection between the theme of the essay, the chapter title it comes from, and why your particular song would be curated where it is. What is the song exemplifying, either through its lyrics, beat, tone, rhythm, or other musical elements, and how does that connect to the themes/messages you found in your assigned essay?

When we are all done, each group will present their work to the class and your classmates will be able to chime in or ask questions.

Group 1: **Names: Justin, Hugh, Austin, Malachi, Elaine Lopez**	"Intermission: Leisure & Lifestyle" Essay: "The Cookout" Song: "Glowed Up ft. Anderson .Paak" by Kaytranada
Summarize the essay for the class in no more than 5 sentences	This essay depicts an anecdote of someone being invited to a cookout, along with an explanation of the origin of cookouts.The essay also says they became popular in the Pre Civil War USA, how they were banned by whites out of fear of potential uprisings, and how cookouts continue today.
What particular role or power does the author see food playing in their lives and the world around them? In other words, what does the author argue food has the ability to do other than provide us with the energy we need to live and breathe?	The author sees cookouts as a powerful way for his community to socialize. In 2018, after the cops were called on a cookout, the black community in Oakland came together and created a cookout where thousands attended, as a symbol of unity.
After listening to the song assigned to you, briefly theorize/perform a close reading in which you make a connection between the theme of the essay, the chapter title it comes from, and why your particular song would be curated where it is. What is the song exemplifying, either through its lyrics, beat, tone, rhythm, or other musical elements, and how does that connect to the themes/messages you found in your assigned essay?	The song is about turning something negative into a positive. The African American community transformed cookouts from something that they had to do during the period of enslavement into a unified celebration. Additionally, the song and essay both discuss reclaiming power over oneself, which is what occured in Oakland in 2018 when the African American community came together in unity in order to protest police action against their cookout in the park. "I'm glowed up Yeah, same time stealin' Same squad chillin'"

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name Salem Martinez

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

Salem was my English teacher in fall 2024. We had classes together twice a week.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Because of Salem, I was able to gain a lot from the class as I feel like it made me a much better reader, writer, compassionate and open-minded member of my community. I had initially taken the class only to satisfy a requirement, but the class had inspired me to take more English classes in my last year at UCLA.

Because it was a small class, Salem really encouraged everyone to participate and voice their opinions. I found myself feeling more involved with the class and that was not always easy with other classes. He inspired us to think about how the topics discussed in class relate to the outside world.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Salem always encouraged us to delve deeper into the topics discussed in class and speak up. The topics discussed were heavy topics, which Salem acknowledged and made the environment comfortable and safe for us to discuss them. He did a good job facilitating an inclusive atmosphere, so a lot of us felt comfortable sharing our thoughts.

Salem also encouraged everyone to speak up by giving them space. For students who were not super confident in public speaking, he would ask leading questions to help them explain their ideas better and elaborate on their ideas. He also never seemed to mind the amount of questions that students had for him and he always tried to make the learning process as inviting as possible.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Salem's class was one of the most memorable classes I've had at UCLA. A lot of students in the class were actually STEM majors, so a lot of us weren't super familiar with the field to start with. But Salem still made everyone feel like they were capable of participating and their opinions valued. Given his passionate and caring demeanor, I can really see Salem as a great future educator, and I am confident he will be able to inspire a lot of students.

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES UCLA

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11 February 2026

To Whom It May Concern:

I am writing in strong support of Salem Martinez, who has been nominated for a Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants.

I first got to know Salem in the fall of 2019, when they entered the English Department's doctoral program; and we have met regularly since then to discuss their scholarly interests in African American literature and science fiction. Although they have not taken any of my classes for credit, in the spring of 2024 they audited my seminar titled *Black Speculative Fiction*, where they proved to be an especially valuable participant in our group conversations. I readily agreed to serve on their doctoral committee and they are currently at work on a promising dissertation project.

Salem's serving as my teaching assistant in the fall quarter of 2025 gave me the opportunity to view them in a new light—that is, as an experienced and skilled instructor. A survey of early African American literature and crosslisted in both the English and the African American Studies Departments, my class enrolled an extremely diverse group of students. In addition, given the focus of the readings on slavery and the turbulent decades following the Civil War and Emancipation, we necessarily engaged quite charged and, in the current social climate, quite controversial topics. As a result, the demands on my TAs were more complex than what they would otherwise confront. Salem proved to be fully up to the challenge. When I visited one of their section meetings, I noticed immediately the trust that they had established with their students. They maintained a relaxed atmosphere in the classroom even as the fifty-minute period was carefully organized and highly productive. Our conversation following my observation revealed Salem to be exceedingly thoughtful regarding their pedagogical practices, and they were eager to receive and to respond to my feedback. I would add that I particularly appreciated their helpful suggestions when I sought advice that quarter regarding course construction, student evaluation, and the like. And both during exam and paper norming sessions with my TAs and when I had occasion to review their graded essays, I was struck by the thoroughness and clarity of Salem's comments. Such conscientiousness requires considerable time and energy; and Salem's efforts manifested an unstinting dedication to enabling the academic success of our students and, moreover, to ensuring their general welfare at a time when many have been experiencing significant stress and anxiety.

In sum, Salem Martinez is a gifted and deeply committed instructor who fulfilled their duties as my TA with exemplary rigor, empathy, common sense, and diligence. I can recommend them for a Distinguished Teaching Award with enthusiasm.

Sincerely,



Richard Yarborough
Professor Emeritus of English &
African American Studies